



Research

[ARTICLES](#)

[DATA VISUALIZATIONS](#)

[DATA LIBRARY](#)

[VIDEOS](#)

Search



Data, Local Market Insights, Market Clock, months supply

Market Clock 2026 Q1: The Most Fragmented Housing Market in Years

By [Jake Krimmel](#)

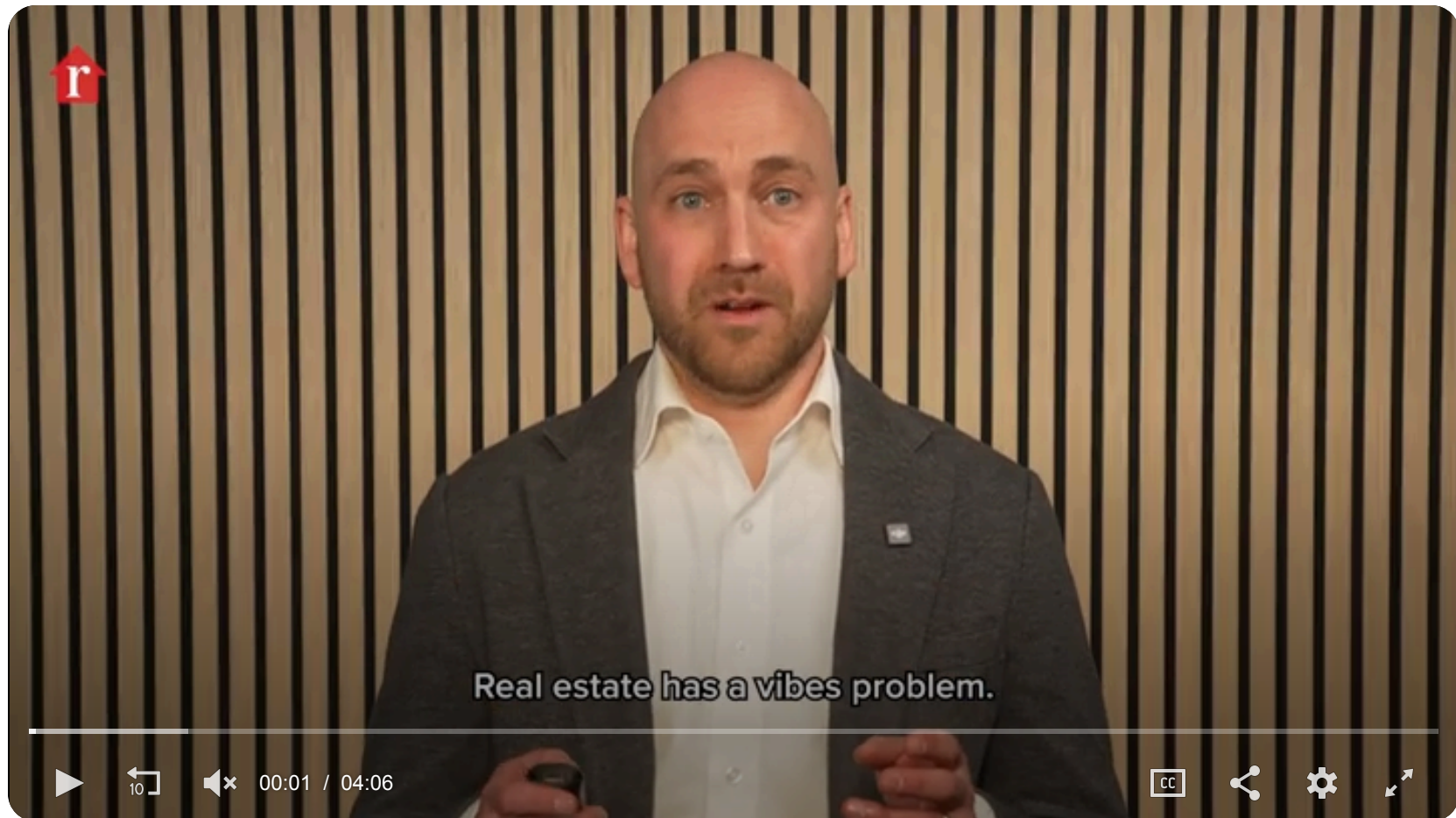
Apr 09, 2026





 **realtor.com®**

Market Clock



In this inaugural edition of the Realtor. com® Market Clock quarterly report, we examine where the nation's 50 largest housing markets stand on the buyer-seller leverage spectrum, how they've shifted over the recent housing cycle, and what the spread across metros tells us about the state of the market heading into the spring buying season. For a

deeper look at how the **Market Clock** works and how to interpret it, [see our companion guide](#).

KEY FINDINGS

- **National reading: 3 o'clock.** The national housing market is balanced but gradually loosening as the cycle moves in a more buyer-friendly direction heading into the spring 2026 season.
- **Most fragmented market in at least 8 years.** The top 50 metros span 9 of the clock's 12 positions, from peak seller's markets in parts of the Midwest and New England to buyer's markets across much of the South.
- **Local cycles, not national trends.** Over the past six months, some metros have continued loosening toward buyers, others have barely budged, and a handful have reversed course and tightened. It is local cycles—rather than national trends—that determine what it actually feels like to buy or sell a home.

The Realtor. com® Market Clock is a new diagnostic tool that places each of the 50 largest U. S. metros on a 12-hour clockface measuring buyer-seller negotiating leverage, from peak seller's market at 12 o'clock to peak buyer's market at 6 o'clock. It is updated monthly at [realtor. com/MarketClock](https://www.realtor.com/MarketClock).

IN THIS REPORT

1. [Where Markets Are Today](#)
2. [Market Clock Through the Last Cycle](#)
3. [Where Markets Have Moved in the Past Six Months](#)

4. What Comes Next

Where Markets Are Today

The national housing market sits at 3 o'clock right now, using data through December 2025. That places it in the 'Balanced – Loosening' quadrant, and heading toward a buyer's market though it is not necessarily fast approaching one. However, the national reading conceals a wide array of local conditions across metros. Looking across the top 50 markets, the buyer-seller dynamics span nearly the full face of the market clock, from peak seller's markets to peak buyer's markets and most conditions in between.

What Time is it Right Now Across the Top 50 Metros?

Across the top 50 metros, 13 (26%) are currently seller's markets; 23 (46%) are Balanced-Loosening; 8 (16%) are buyer's markets; and 6 (12%) are Balanced-Tightening. Digging deeper, 16 of the top 50 markets sit at either 4 or 5 on the market clock, in the Late Balanced or Early Buyer's market phase. This echoes what a host of individual data series have pointed to over the past several months: many metros, especially but not exclusively those in the South and West, are moving in an increasingly buyer-friendly direction. What the market clock also provides is positioning, not just direction. It's not just that the metros at 4 and 5 are moving in a buyer-friendly direction, it's that they are likely to keep doing so as they have not yet reached the peak buyer point.

The top 50 metros span 9 of the clock's 12 positions — the widest distribution since our data began in 2018.

SELLER'S MARKETS — 13 METROS

Northeast: 3 | Midwest: 7 | South: 1 | West: 2

11 o'clock – Early Seller: Providence, Grand Rapids, Kansas City, Milwaukee, St. Louis, San Francisco

12 o'clock – Peak Seller: Hartford, Chicago, Indianapolis, Virginia Beach

1 o'clock – Late Seller: Boston, Columbus, San Jose

BALANCED – LOOSENING – 23 METROS + USA OVERALL

Northeast: 1 | Midwest: 3 | South: 12 | West: 7

2 o'clock – Early Balanced: Dallas, Louisville, Denver, Los Angeles, Sacramento, San Diego, Tucson

3 o'clock – Balanced: USA Avg. , Philadelphia, Cincinnati, Cleveland, Birmingham, Houston, Memphis, Richmond, San Antonio

4 o'clock – Late Balanced: Detroit, Baltimore, Charlotte, Oklahoma City, Raleigh, Washington DC, Las Vegas, Phoenix

BUYER'S MARKETS — 8 METROS**Northeast: 0 | Midwest: 0 | South: 7 | West: 1****5 o'clock – Early Buyer:** Atlanta, Austin, Jacksonville, Miami, Nashville, Orlando, Tampa, Riverside**6 o'clock – Peak Buyer:** NONE**7 o'clock – Late Buyer:** NONE**BALANCED – TIGHTENING — 6 METROS****Northeast: 3 | Midwest: 1 | South: 0 | West: 2****8 o'clock – Early Balanced:** NONE**9 o'clock – Balanced:** New York, Minneapolis**10 o'clock – Late Balanced:** Buffalo, Pittsburgh, Portland, Seattle[Back to top](#)

Market Clock Through the Last Cycle

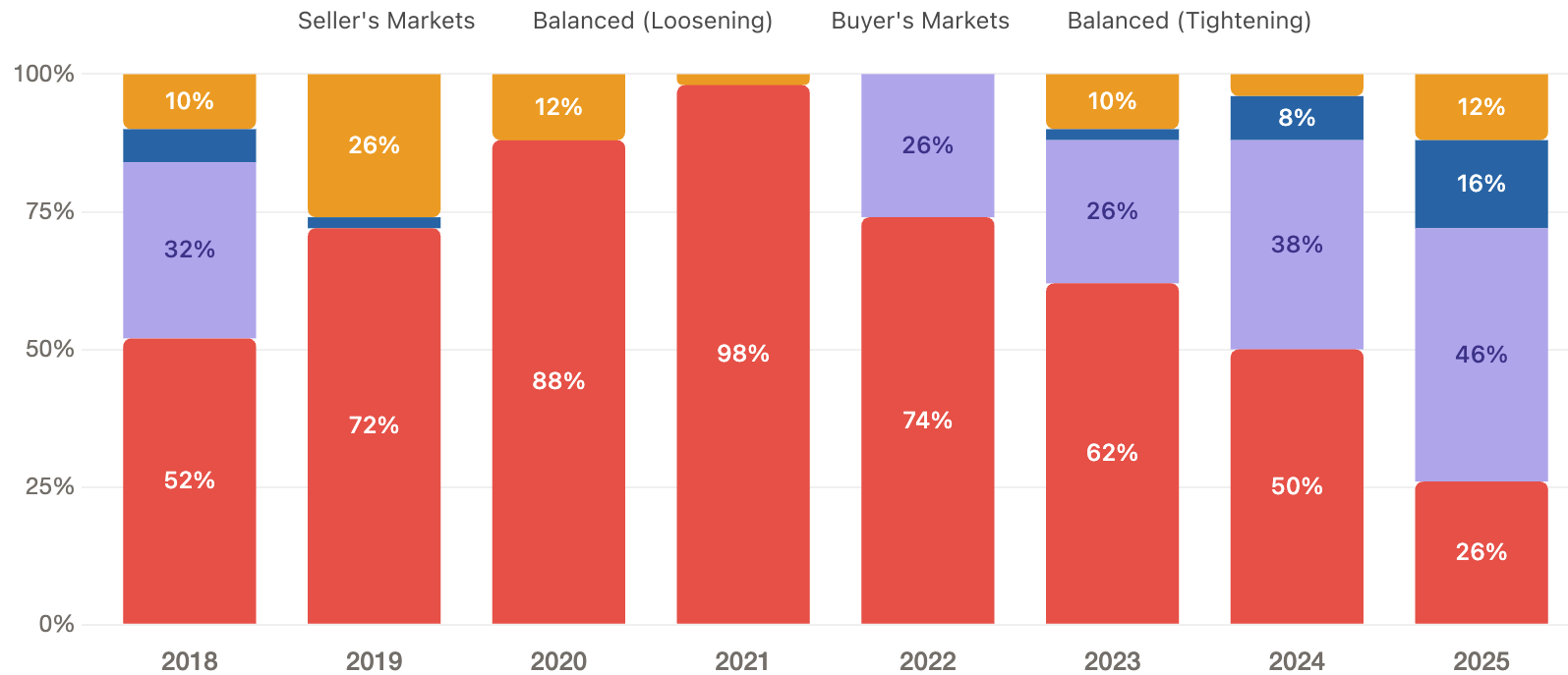
Looking back across the last housing cycle provides a simple validation of the Market Clock framework. If the clock meaningfully captures buyer-seller dynamics, it should reflect the

broad arc of the pandemic boom, the post-rate-hike lock-in effect which froze both inventory and housing demand, and the recent buyer-friendly trend paired with a stark regional divide. Importantly, the Clock should do so not only at the national aggregate level but also across the top 50 metros, revealing when the largest markets moved in unison and when local conditions diverged.

Looking across the full 8 year history for which we have the Market Clock data clearly shows the arc of the recent housing cycle. Even in 2018, the slight majority of metros were classified as seller's markets. And heading into the pandemic in December 2019, 48 of the top 50 markets were either in seller or tightening territory. In fact, 40 of the top 50 metros were either late-balanced at 10 o'clock or early seller's at 11 o'clock. This underscores exactly why the pandemic-era housing market boomed like it did: initial conditions were already extremely tight and seller-friendly. It was only after the interest rate increase in 2022 that some markets started to loosen (seen in purple). By December 2024, still half the markets were Seller's and just 4 (8%) were Buyer's. A year later, the number of Seller's markets fell by roughly half, while the number of outright Buyer's markets doubled.

Market Clock — Share of Metros by Quadrant

December Snapshot, Top 50 Metros + National Avg.



The 2019–2025 Cycle in Four Acts

The table below reports the share of the top 50 metros in each Market Clock quadrant for December 2019, 2021, 2023, and 2025. These four snapshots capture the cycle in four acts: the pre-pandemic tightening stage set in 2019, the pandemic-era seller dominance in 2021, the rate-shock cooling and lock-in period in 2023, and the more fragmented landscape emerging in 2025. The national clock quadrant for each year is shown in the red text; note it does not necessarily coincide with where the majority of metros sit, which is shown in orange when it differs.

Quadrant	Hours	2019	2021	2023	2025
Sellers Market	11, 12, 1	72%	98%	62%	26%
Balanced – Loosening	2, 3, 4	0%	0%	26%	46%
Buyers Market	5, 6, 7	2%	0%	2%	16%
Balanced – Tightening	8, 9, 10	26%	2%	10%	12%

Act 1 — December 2019: Pre-Pandemic Tightening

In December 2019, conditions were already tight in many large markets. Seventy-two percent of the top 50 metros were in seller-leaning phases, while 26% were in balanced-tightening phases. The national market, however, was classified as balanced-tightening. This illustrates an important feature of the framework: the national reading can lag leading metros, particularly if the largest markets are slow to turn.

Act 2 — December 2021: Pandemic-Era Seller Dominance

By December 2021, the compression was dramatic. Ninety-eight percent of the top 50 metros were in seller-leaning phases. Only one market (Buffalo) was outside seller territory, and it would re-enter a seller's market just a month later. This was the peak of pandemic-era demand, just before mortgage rates began to rise and the cycle turned. The clock registers this period as an extreme seller-dominated regime across nearly the entire country.

Act 3 — December 2023: Rate-Shock Cooling and Lock-In

By December 2023, demand had cooled materially following higher mortgage rates, but tight supply and lock-in effects kept many markets seller-leaning. Sixty-two percent of the top 50 metros remained in seller phases, even as 26% had shifted into balanced-loosening territory. The national clock read balanced-loosening, reflecting softening conditions overall, but the cross-section shows that most large metros were still relatively tight. The Market Clock framework captures both facts simultaneously.

Act 4 — December 2025: Fragmentation

By December 2025, as discussed above, the picture had widened considerably. Only 26% of the top 50 metros were seller-leaning. Forty-six percent were in balanced-loosening phases and 16% were in buyer-leaning phases. Unlike the compression of 2021, the current environment is characterized by dispersion. Some markets have become meaningfully buyer-friendly, while others—particularly in parts of the Midwest and Northeast—remain comparatively tight.

Where Markets Have Moved in the Past Six Months

The long-run arc from 2018 through 2025 tells a story of compression followed by dispersion; the top 50 markets moved in lockstep during the pandemic, tightening almost uniformly but have since fanned out across the face of the Market Clock. But recent fragmentation has also happened over the short-run. Even over the past six months, local markets have been pulling in sharply different directions. Between June and December

2025, the top 50 metros split roughly three ways: 19 loosened toward buyers, 14 tightened back toward sellers, and 17 held steady.



Among loosening markets, the shifts were often dramatic. Several metros swung from seller's markets into balanced or buyer-friendly territory in just six months, as growing inventory and longer selling times continued to erode seller leverage. At the same time, a notable group of markets that had appeared to be cooling at midyear reversed course and tightened back toward sellers. And a sizable share of metros barely moved at all, holding in essentially the same position they occupied six months earlier. All 50 markets are exposed to the same macroeconomic forces, such as mortgage rates, federal policy, broader economic conditions and uncertainty, yet their trajectories diverge because buyer-seller leverage is ultimately shaped by longer-run local trends. That divergence underscores the value of the Market Clock.

All 50 markets are exposed to the same macroeconomic forces, yet their trajectories diverge because buyer-seller leverage is ultimately shaped by longer-run local trends.

Metro Movement — June to December 2025

Clock Hour Change by Metro, Sorted by Magnitude

Seller's Loosening Buyer's Tightening ○ June ● December

All metros

Changed quadrant

Loosening

Tightening

No change

Metro	Jun	Movement	Dec	Change
Minneapolis	3	○	9	→ 6h tightening
New York	3	○	9	→ 6h tightening
Portland	4	○	10	→ 6h tightening
Seattle	4	○	10	→ 6h tightening
Buffalo	3	○	10	→ 5h tightening
Pittsburgh	3	○	10	→ 5h tightening
San Francisco	4	○	11	→ 5h tightening
Cincinnati	11	○	3	→ 4h loosening
Detroit	12	○	4	→ 4h loosening
Richmond	11	○	3	→ 4h loosening
Baltimore	1	○	4	→ 3h loosening
Charlotte	1	○	4	→ 3h loosening
Cleveland	12	○	3	→ 3h loosening
Jacksonville	2	○	5	→ 3h loosening
Denver	4	○	2	→ 2h tightening
Los Angeles	4	○	2	→ 2h tightening
Sacramento	4	○	2	→ 2h tightening
San Diego	4	○	2	→ 2h tightening

Tucson	4		2	→ 2h tightening
Atlanta	4		5	→ 1h loosening
Austin	4		5	→ 1h loosening
Dallas	1		2	→ 1h loosening
Grand Rapids	12		11	→ 1h loosening
Indianapolis	1		12	→ 1h tightening
Louisville	1		2	→ 1h loosening
Milwaukee	12		11	→ 1h loosening
Nashville	4		5	→ 1h loosening
Oklahoma City	3		4	→ 1h loosening
Providence	12		11	→ 1h loosening
Riverside	4		5	→ 1h loosening
San Antonio	2		3	→ 1h loosening
St. Louis	12		11	→ 1h loosening
USA Avg	4		3	→ 1h tightening
Virginia Beach	1		12	→ 1h tightening
Birmingham	3		3	—
Boston	1		1	—
Chicago	12		12	—
Columbus	1		1	—
Hartford	12		12	—
Houston	3		3	—

Kansas City	11	11	—
Las Vegas	4	4	—
Memphis	3	3	—
Miami	5	5	—
Orlando	5	5	—
Philadelphia	3	3	—
Phoenix	4	4	—
Raleigh	4	4	—
San Jose	1	1	—
Tampa	5	5	—
Washington, DC	4	4	—

To see where your metro sits on the Market Clock today, visit [realtor.com/MarketClock](https://www.realtor.com/MarketClock).

[Back to top](#)

What Comes Next

The Market Clock is built to make sense of a housing market that has become increasingly fragmented, often along regional lines, and at a time when national housing narratives have become less representative of local conditions. This inaugural report placed the nation's top 50 metros on the clockface and explored what their positions reveal about the

wide variation in buyer-seller leverage today and how conditions have shifted in recent years.

The Market Clock will be updated quarterly, tracking how local markets move through the cycle and whether the fragmentation we see today deepens, narrows, or shifts in new directions. Each edition will map where metros stand, how they've moved, and what the patterns reveal about the housing cycle ahead.

New to the Market Clock?

Learn how the Clock works, what each of the 12 phases means for buyers and sellers, and how to interpret your metro's position.

[**Read the Market Clock Guide →**](#)

What time is it in your market?

See where your metro sits on the Market Clock right now.

[Visit the Market Clock →](#)[Back to top](#)

Methodology

The Realtor. com® Market Clock is built on Realtor. com® housing market data and analysis of deed records to classify the top 50 U. S. metropolitan areas and a national aggregate into one of 12 phases of the buyer-seller leverage cycle. The framework synthesizes measures of market balance, pace and momentum, and pricing pressure into a single clock position for each metro. Data will be updated monthly and a report released quarterly. Data span January 2018 through December 2025. The 50 largest U. S. metropolitan areas are defined by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB-202301) and Claritas 2025 estimates of household counts.

Sign up for updates

Join our mailing list to receive the latest data and research.

[Join ▶](#)

Related Articles

Employment

April 2026 Jobs Report: Labor Market Shows Signs of Stabilization

April's jobs report painted a picture of labor market stabilization — and against the current economic...

Housing Finance

Mortgage Rates Rise to 6.37%

The Freddie Mac 30-year mortgage rate climbed 7 basis points to 6.37%, extending last week's upward...

Affordability

New-Construction Insights: Urban New Builds Are Scarce and Expensive

A vast majority of new builds are in suburban zip codes, and the new construction premium...

Hottest Markets

April 2026 Hottest Housing Markets

Springfield, MA was once again the hottest housing market in the country for the second month...

WSJ/RDC Emerging Housing
Markets Index

Luxury Cut: The Spring 2026 Wall Street Journal/Realtor.com Housing Market Ranking

The Spring 2026 WSJ/realtor.com
Luxury Housing Market Ranking
highlights top markets poised for
home price growth...

WSJ/RDC Emerging Housing
Markets Index

The Spring 2026 Wall Street Journal/Realtor.com Housing Market Ranking

The Spring 2026 ranking evaluates
the 200 most populous U. S.
metropolitan areas using a
combination of...



REALTORS'
RELIEF
FOUNDATION

.RealEstate

[About us](#)

[Careers](#)

[Accessibility](#)

[Feedback](#)

[Media room](#)

[Ad Choices](#)

[Advertise with us](#)

[Agent support](#)

[Privacy](#)

[Terms](#)

[Home Made](#)

[Tech Blog](#)

[Agent Blog](#)

[Sitemap](#)

**Do Not Sell or
Share My Personal
Information**

Get the app



Any mortgage lead generation activity in the state of Connecticut is performed by MSIM, LLC (NMLS #2121192), a subsidiary of Move, Inc.

© 1995-2026 National Association of REALTORS ® and Move, Inc. All rights reserved.